

Day 7 — Group Work: Balance and Imbalance

Module: Panchabhūta · **Band:** Middle · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

By the end of this lesson, students will identify a real local example of one *pañcabhūta* being “out of balance” in their environment and propose one observable consequence and one mitigation action.

Materials

- 5 large pieces of chart paper, one labelled with each element.
- Sticky notes (~30) per group.
- Markers.
- Optional: 3–5 short newspaper clippings about local environmental issues (air quality, water shortage, waste/landfill, heatwave, deforestation).

Vocabulary

- No new Sanskrit. Introduce the word **imbalance** as the operating concept of the day.

Lesson flow

Warm-up (5 min)

- Daily prompt — 2 students.
- “All week we’ve talked about the elements as if they sit nicely in their boxes. Today we’ll see what happens when one of them takes over — or disappears.”

Core (15 min) — From individual elements to imbalanced systems

1. **Open question, take 3 answers:** “Can you think of a place where one of the five elements is too much, or too little?”
 - Example answers students typically give: too much smoke (*tejas* or *vāyu* — pollution), no water (*ap* — drought), too much plastic waste (*prthvī* — landfill), too noisy a road (*ākāśa* + *śabda* — sound pollution), too hot a city (*tejas* — heat island).
2. **Frame the principle (write on board):**

A healthy environment has all five elements in balance. When one is overloaded or depleted, the others suffer.
3. **Mini case study together — air pollution in Indian cities:**
 - Too much *tejas* in the form of vehicle exhaust → *vāyu* becomes carrying polluted matter → *ap* (rain) becomes acidic → *prthvī* (soil) absorbs the acid → plants struggle → less oxygen → *vāyu* worsens further.

- Notice: an imbalance in one element cascades.

Activity (20 min) — Five-Element Imbalance Map

In groups of 4, each group tackles ONE element. On their large chart paper they fill four quadrants:

- **What this element does for us** (positive contributions)
- **What an excess looks like in our area** (one specific local example)
- **What a depletion looks like in our area** (one specific local example)
- **One small thing students our age can actually do** (concrete, doable this week)

Each group sticks their chart on the wall. Gallery walk: students rotate, read all five charts, and place a sticky note on the action they'd most commit to.

Wrap-up (5 min)

- Each group reads aloud their chosen action (just the one line).
- Note: “*Notice how no single action solves everything — but every chart has at least one thing that’s doable.*”
- Preview Day 8: project work begins. Bring all your materials tomorrow.

Student-facing content

Balance and imbalance

A healthy environment has all five elements in balance. When one takes over or disappears, the others suffer.

Examples of imbalance you might recognise:

Imbalance	What you observe
Too much <i>tejas</i> (heat)	Urban heat-island; summer power cuts
Too little <i>ap</i> (water)	Drought; failed crops; long water-queue at the tap
Polluted <i>vāyu</i> (air)	Smog; difficulty breathing on bad-air days
Polluted <i>pṛthvī</i> (earth)	Plastic waste; barren soil; landfill near homes
Noisy <i>ākāśa</i>	Sound pollution; sleep disturbance; bad concentration

The Sanskrit concept *Vasudhaiva Kuṭumbakam* — “the earth is one family” — is the ecological framing for this. We’ll meet it again in Module 13.

Homework

- Bring **all** project materials to tomorrow’s session. The work begins in earnest.
- For your project, consider: is there a small element of “imbalance” worth showing alongside the element’s main story?

Differentiation

- **One tier up:** Pick TWO elements and explain how an imbalance in one causes an imbalance in the other. Be specific.

- **One tier down:** Focus on choosing ONE concrete action you can commit to this week (carry a water bottle to reduce plastic, switch off lights when leaving a room, etc.). The systems-thinking can come later.

Teacher notes

- This lesson connects to NEP §11.8 (multidisciplinary linkage) and is a natural lead-in to Module 13 (Indic Ecology) when the time comes.
- Some students may feel discouraged by the scale of the problems. Don't soften the reality, but anchor every imbalance to a doable response. The point is agency, not despair.
- If your school is in a location with a *specific* well-known environmental issue (e.g. a polluted river, a heavily quarried hillside), centre that as the case study and skip the air-pollution example.

Citation(s) used in this lesson

- *Vasudhaiva Kuṭumbakam* is foreshadowed but not cited. Save full sourcing for Module 13.
- No new RAG citations.